
Read the pawns before choosing a plan

START WITH THE CENTRAL PAWN SKELETON

Name which pawns can challenge each other. Identify half-open files, outposts and likely breaks. Then check whether piece placement makes the strategic plan tactically possible.

A STRUCTURAL TARGET IS NOT AUTOMATICALLY WEAK

A pawn can be isolated but active, backward but tactically defended, or doubled while supporting important central squares. Evaluate the pieces and king safety alongside the pawn labels.

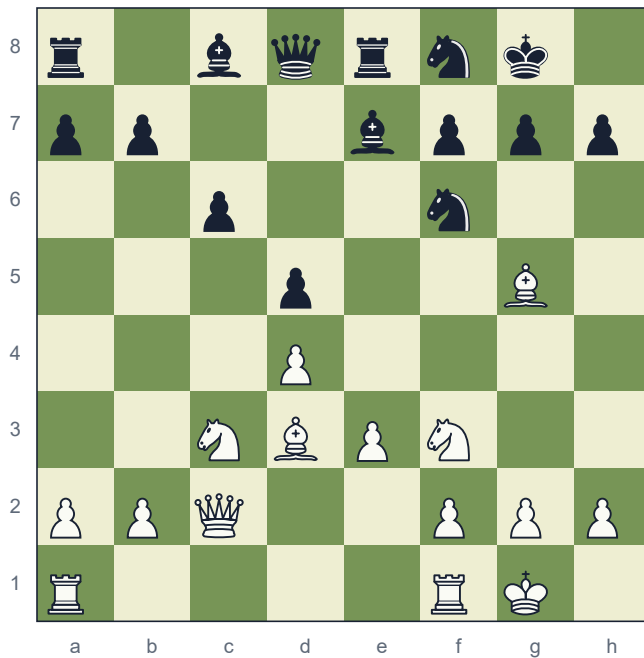
QUESTIONS FOR EVERY POSITION

What is my least active piece? What does Black want next? Which pawn break improves my position? Which trade helps the opponent? What forcing move could invalidate my plan?

USE THIS BOOKLET IN BOTH COLORS

Practicing the Black side of your chosen White structures teaches you the counterplay. A repertoire becomes more reliable when you understand the opponent's best idea.

Carlsbad and the minority attack



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

The c-file is half-open for White and the black c6 pawn can become a target after b4-b5. Your queenside minority tries to create a weakness, not a passed pawn immediately.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Coordinate a rook on b1 or c1, prepare b4, and assess b5. If ...cxb5, examine the isolated d-pawn or weak c-file squares; if ...c5, recalculate the central structure.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black seeks ...Ne4, kingside activity and the freeing ...c5. If those threats are urgent, a slow pawn plan may be too slow.

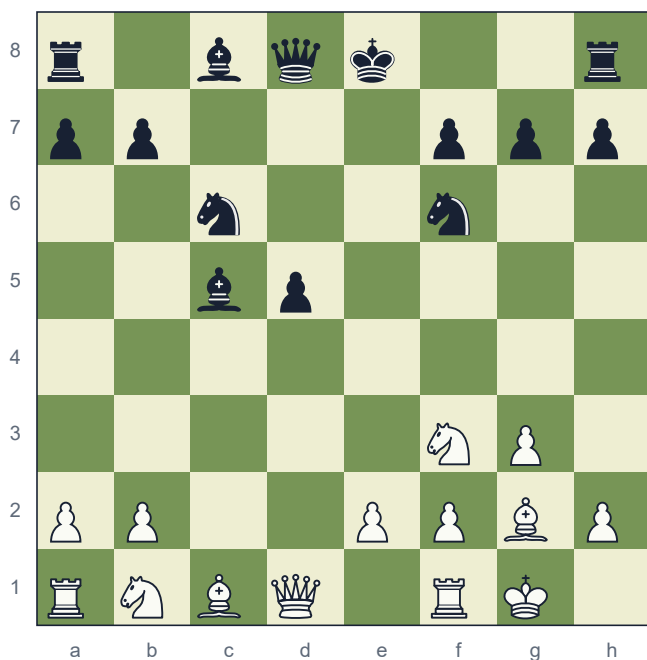
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Which piece needs improvement before b4? What exact pawn weakness would b5 create?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Playing against an isolated queen pawn



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

Black's d-pawn has no friendly c- or e-pawn to support it. It controls central squares, so it is not simply a free target.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Restrain its advance, blockade with a suitable piece, and exchange active attacking pieces when favorable. Attack the pawn only after your king and pieces are coordinated.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black wants ...d4 or an initiative before the position simplifies. A poorly timed pawn capture can release all of Black's pieces.

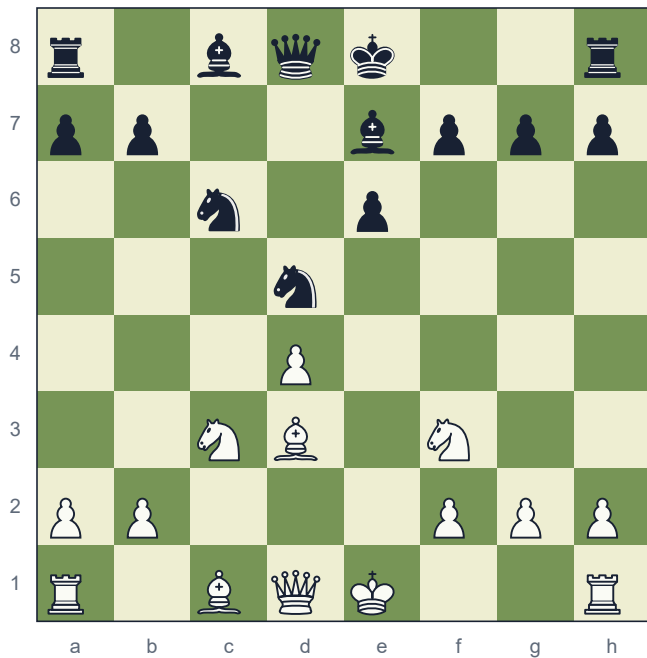
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Which square is directly in front of the isolated pawn? Can you occupy it safely?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Playing with an isolated queen pawn



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

White has an isolated d4 pawn and open central lines. The pawn offers space and activity but can become an endgame burden.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Use active bishops and rooks, keep useful attacking pieces, and prepare d5 if it opens the position favorably. Make the opponent defend threats before they can blockade.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black wants a stable blockade and favorable piece exchanges. Avoid trading into a passive ending simply because it reduces the material.

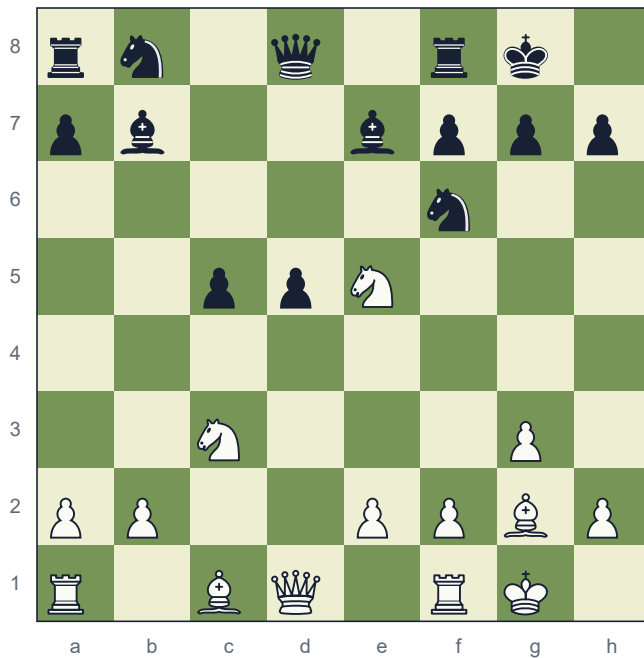
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Which trade favors the blockader? What would have to change for d5 to work?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Hanging pawns: c5 and d5



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

The adjacent black c5 and d5 pawns lack friendly pawns on the neighboring outer files. Together they control useful central squares; after one advances, the other may become weak.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

For the side facing them, pressure both pawns and provoke a concession without allowing a strong advance. For the side owning them, keep activity and choose the right moment to push.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

One careless exchange can turn the pair into a strong passed pawn rather than a weakness. Calculate recaptures before celebrating a structural target.

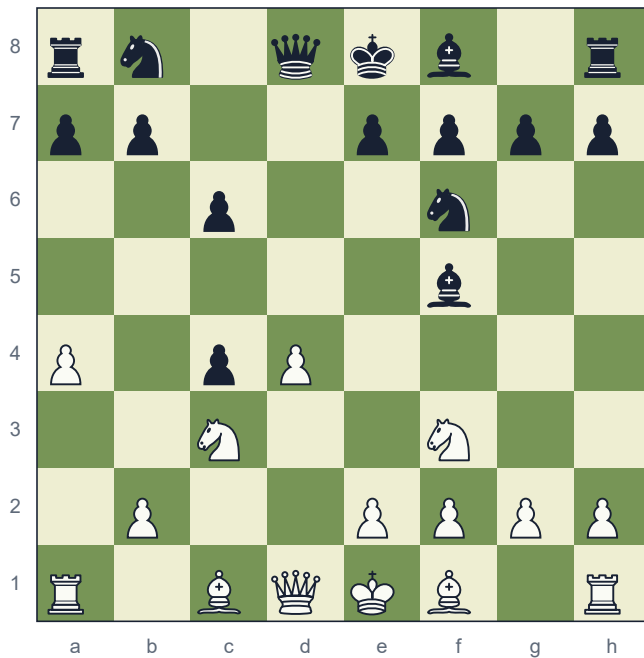
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

If ...d4 is played, which square and pawn become vulnerable?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Slav: the captured c4 pawn



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

Black has captured on c4 and White has played a4. The immediate structural battle concerns whether ...b5 can hold the extra pawn.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Develop e3 and Bxc4 when safe. Do not replace useful development with queen moves just to regain the pawn one move sooner.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black can counter in the center while you recover c4. The later e4 break must be supported against pins and exchanges.

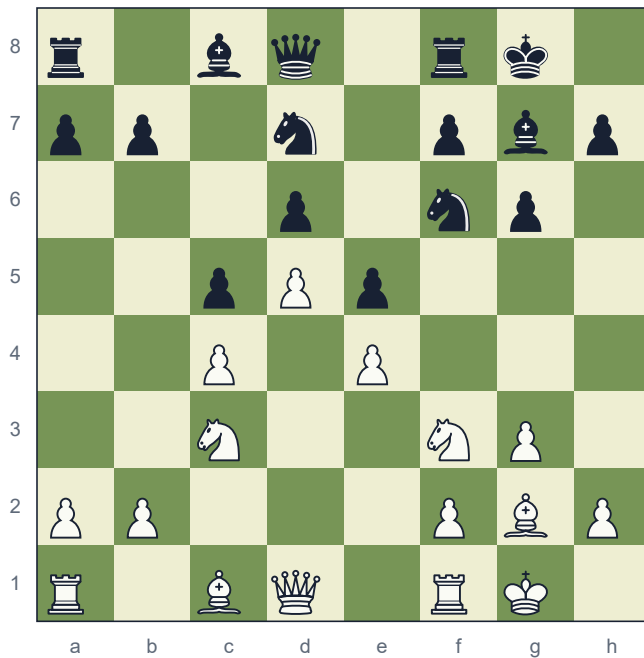
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Why does a4 matter here? Which move opens the bishop that can recover c4?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

The locked Indian center



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

White's d5 and e4 pawns face Black's d6 and e5 pawns. The center is closed, but pawn breaks can reopen it.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Improve the least active minor piece and identify a useful break. Queenside space is valuable only if it creates entry squares or targets. Keep the fianchetto bishop's defensive role in mind.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black can prepare kingside activity or queenside breaks. The exact knight placements decide whether ...f5 or ...b5 is feasible.

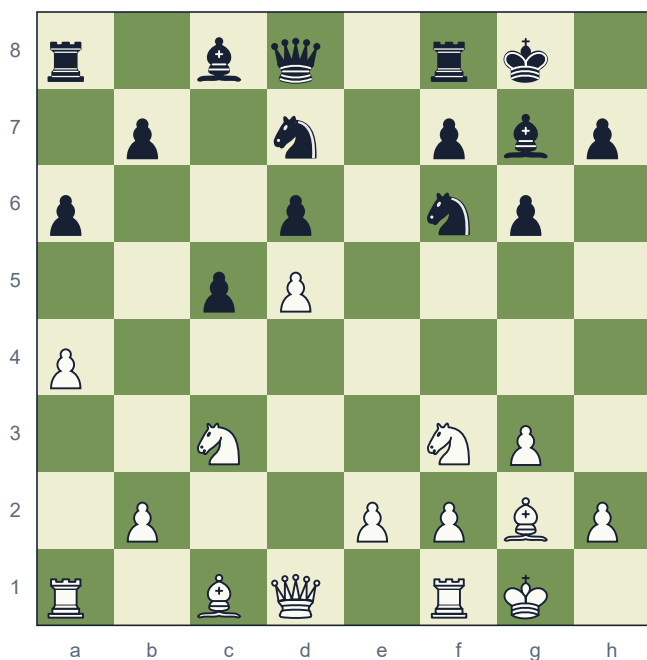
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Which pawn break is realistic for each side? Which knight has the clearest route to a better square?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Modern Benoni: central space versus ...b5



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

White's d5 pawn cramps Black. Black has a queenside majority and a potentially weak d6 pawn, compensated by active diagonals and files.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Restrain ...b5 when useful, develop, and prepare e4-e5. Watch whether exchanging a key bishop would weaken your control of central squares.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black seeks ...b5, ...Re8 and pressure against the center. The d6 pawn is rarely won by a single unsupported attack.

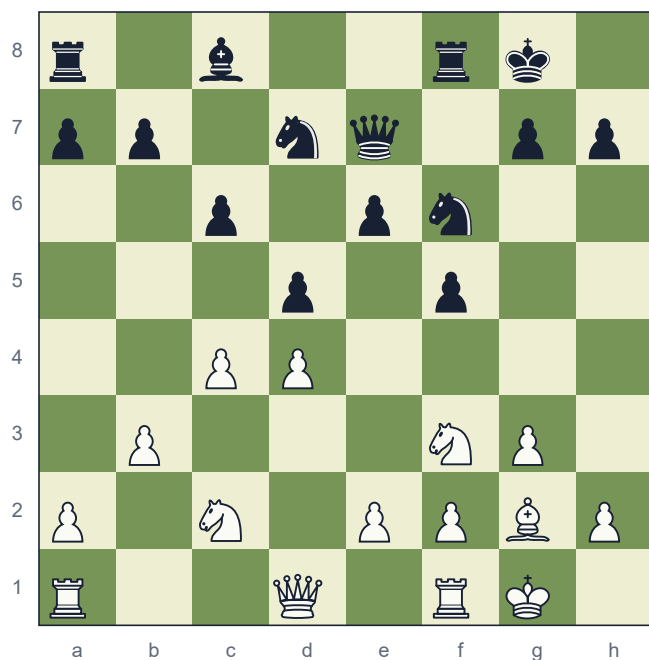
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Does a4 stop ...b5 permanently or only make it harder? What supports an eventual e5 break?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Dutch Stonewall: the e5 square



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

The d5-e6-f5 chain gives Black space and restrains e4, but it leaves e5 as a potential white outpost and limits the c8 bishop.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Challenge the good dark-squared bishop where possible. Maneuver a knight toward e5 only when the exchange consequences are favorable. Use patient piece improvement.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black seeks ...Ne4 and attacking chances near your king. Do not create targets with unnecessary kingside pawn moves.

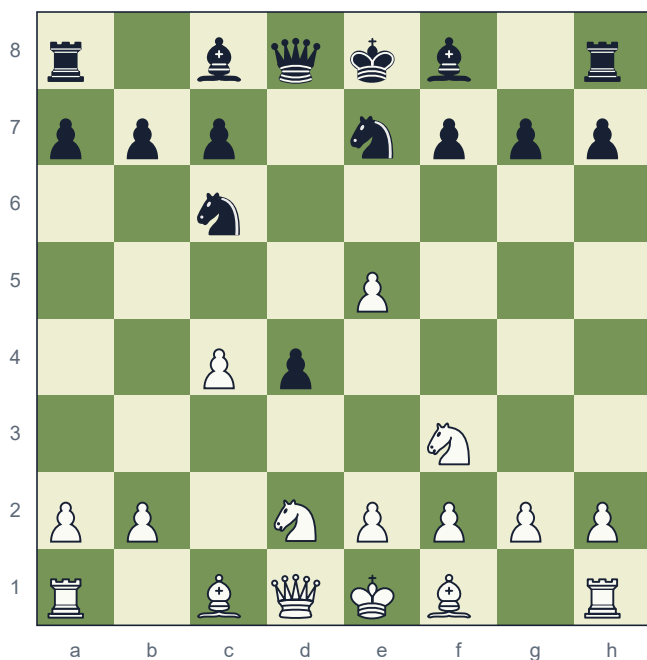
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Which bishop would Black most like to improve? Which trade reduces the attack?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Albin: the advanced d4 wedge



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

The d4 pawn limits your pieces and creates tactics on e3 and along the d-file. White's extra e5 pawn does not remove those threats.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Nbd2-b3 targets d4. Address pins first, and return material if needed to simplify safely. Know the en-passant detail in the e4 line.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black seeks fast development, ...Bg4, and attacks while your king is central. Greedy bishop captures can allow a dangerous passed pawn.

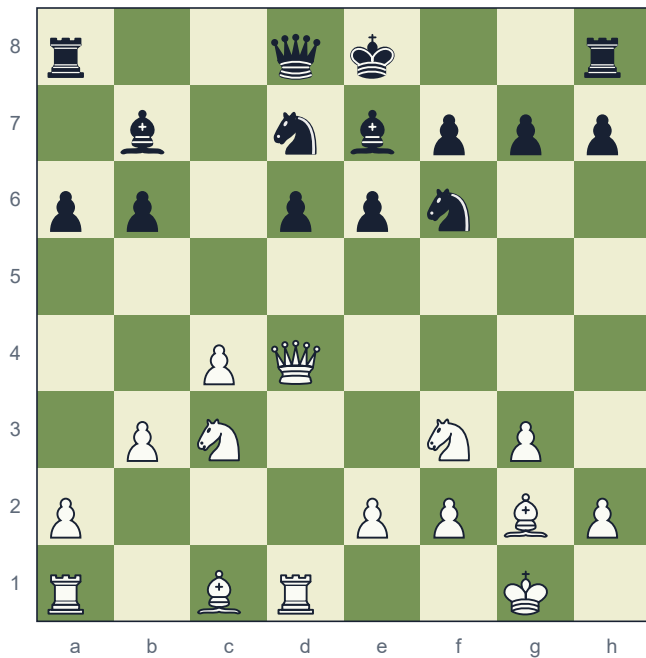
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

What does Nb3 attack? Why is e3 tactically different from a quiet QGD e3 move?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Hedgehog: respect the freeing break



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

Black keeps pawns on a6, b6, d6 and e6 behind compact pieces. White has more space, but that space can become vulnerable if overextended.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Improve pieces and watch ...b5 and ...d5. Do not attack a compact position by creating more weak pawns than targets.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black waits for a central or queenside break that activates several pieces at once. A quiet move may be a tactical preparation.

WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Which break would free Black's position? Can it be prevented usefully, or should you prepare to meet it?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.